Committee[1] was held, there were signs of enthusiasm among the Congress workers of Bengal. The most potent impetus to the new awakening came, however, from the side of the Government.

It was an auspicious moment for the Indian Nationalists when in November 1927 the Viceroy, Lord Irwin, made an announcement, regarding the appointment of the Indian Statutory Commission. The appointment was made under Section 84a of the Government of India Act, 1919, which provided for decennial reviews of the political situation in India, somewhat reminiscent of the political surveys made by the British Parliament into the affairs of the East India Company at the time of the renewal of the Company's Charter. Since the Statutory Commission was due in 1929, it was rather surprising to find a Tory Government accelerating the date of the Commission. The Indian National Congress had been pressing since 1920 for a Round Table Conference *for revising the Constitution, with a view to the early introduction* of Dominion Home Rule, but this demand had been consistently turned down by the British Government. The Conservative Party had never taken kindly to the Reforms of 1919, for which the Liberal, Mr. Montagu, had been largely responsible, though Indian opinion considered them inadequate and unsatisfactory. They, therefore, wanted to dispose of the Indian question themselves while they were in power, so that the Labour Party, if they happened to succeed them, would not be able to make any further concessions to the Indian demand for Home Rule. Since the next General Election in England was due in 1929, the Conservative Cabinet found it necessary to appoint the Statutory Commission in 1927.

The Commission was composed of Sir John Simon (Chairman), Viscount Burnham, Lord Strathcona, Hon. Edward Cadogan, Mr. Stephen Walsh, Major Attlee and Col. Lane Fox (Mr. Walsh resigned and was succeeded by Mr. Vernon Hartshorn.) There were seven members, of whom two were Labourites, one (viz. the Chairman) was a Liberal, and the rest were Conservatives. Thus the co-operation of all the political parties in Britain was secured for the work of the Commission. The Commission was charged with inquiring into 'the working of the system of government, the growth of education and the development of represen-

[1] At this meeting of the Bengal Congress Committee the writer was elected President and Mr Kiron Sankar Roy, Secretary